KERALA

PINARAYI GETS ON THE BUS

By Jeemon Jacob



FOR THE PEOPLE
CM Pinarayi and ministers at a Navakerala event in Thrissur, Dec. 6

The Opposition is often found calculating the dent it could make in the ruling BJP's Lok Sabha tally in one state or the other. The focus rarely goes to internal competition within the INDIA bloc. But look no further than Kerala for a compelling counter-image: the Congress had won 15 of its 20 seats in 2019, over one-fourth of its national tally of 52. **Pinarayi Vijayan**, *the dour-faced chief minister and CPI(M) strongman, is on a mission to ensure there will be no easy encore. 'Navakerala Sadas (New Kerala Conference)', a 36-day bus tour from the state's northern tip to capital Thiruvananthapuram in the deep south by the CM and his 'mobile cabinet', is on its last leg.* INDIA TODAY's **Jeemon Jacob** *travelled on board the bus on a short stretch from Perumbavoor to Kothamangalam in Ernakulam district on December 10 and spoke to Pinarayi. Excerpts from the interaction:*

On the Navakerala Sadas
It has become a people's movement and evoked great response, cutting across politics, religion and age. More and more people are joining it and sharing their developmental dreams. I'm touched by their enthusiasm. It makes me more responsible about my task. The cheering crowds in every nook and corner of the state indicate they support the Left Democratic Front government's good governance.

On Opposition and media allegations that the programme is a "political stunt" and an avoidable extravaganza when the state is passing through a financial crisis
(*Laughs*) I'm not a person who designs political stunts. The conference has been introduced in all 140 assembly constituencies so that people can share their developmental aspirations. It's the first-ever exercise of its kind in the history of Kerala. We invited 41 MLAs from Opposition parties and never wanted to make it an LDF programme. Initially, many of them expressed their willingness to join the programme. The pro-Opposition media naturally has several points of discord with us. Our government is not run by their wishes or modulations. We depend on people, not the headlines. You have travelled in the bus and realised what minimum luxury it has.

On reports that, following what Rahul Gandhi did in 2019, Narendra Modi may contest this time from Kerala for his second seat in the 2024 Lok Sabha election
I am not in the least concerned. Rahul Gandhi may seek re-election from Kerala as he has no safe constituency. I don't know about Modi's entry. We are not a party scared of candidates contesting from Kerala. We will have candidates against them if they contest. We are bothered only about convincing the people of the state why more members of the LDF are needed in the Lok Sabha when the nation is passing through a critical stage, facing threats to its secular credentials and our democratic institutions destabilised.

> **"THE CONGRESS MUST UNDERSTAND THE GROUND REALITY AND SHED ITS SUPERIORITY COMPLEX. IT DOESN'T HAVE THE POLITICAL MUSCLE TO DEFEAT THE BJP ON ITS OWN"**

On the recent assembly poll results and their impact on the INDIA front
The Congress doesn't have the political